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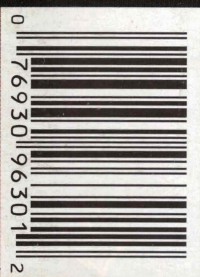
by Brian Kibler

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Learning Legions in Sealed

Ten Rules to Remember

by Jeff Cunningham

Picture yourself on a crowded bus. It's hot and sweaty, and there's nowhere to move. At the next stop, a throng of school kids bustles on, creating face-to-face, wall-to-wall, breathing-down-your-neck tension. Welcome to *Legions Sealed Deck*: a teeming mass of creatures. It's an environment vastly different from other Sealed formats—even from straight *Onslaught Sealed*.

Onslaught is based around creature interactions, so certain tenets of **Magic**—those focusing on creatures—are more important than in other environments. Understanding and utilizing the rules of tempo and mana curve is vital in creature-based formats. Add *Legions*'s hoards of creatures and hat trick of new abilities to the mix, and following these rules becomes even more critical.

Here are ten rules you're going to want to keep in mind when crafting your *Onslaught/Legions* sealed decks.

REMOVAL ISN'T A RIGHT, IT'S A PRIVILEGE

In *Onslaught/Legions* Sealed, removal is at a premium. With a high creature-to-spell ratio, the available removal must be maximized. This creates a balanced deck, one that can do more than pump out creature after creature. A deck has to be able to deal with the bomb creatures *Onslaught* Limited is known for and the fragile but annoying ones like Sparksmith and Wellwisher as well. Of course, top-notch removal cards like Shock, Cruel Revival, and Solar Blast are staples, but the second tier of removal is also worth considering, even if it means cutting a solid creature. I consider anything with provoke playable because it can function as removal. Also playable are mediocre cards like Mistform Mask. With the addition of *Legions*, I find myself playing with the Mask whenever I get it and am playing blue. Being able to deal with problem creatures is that important. Be prepared.

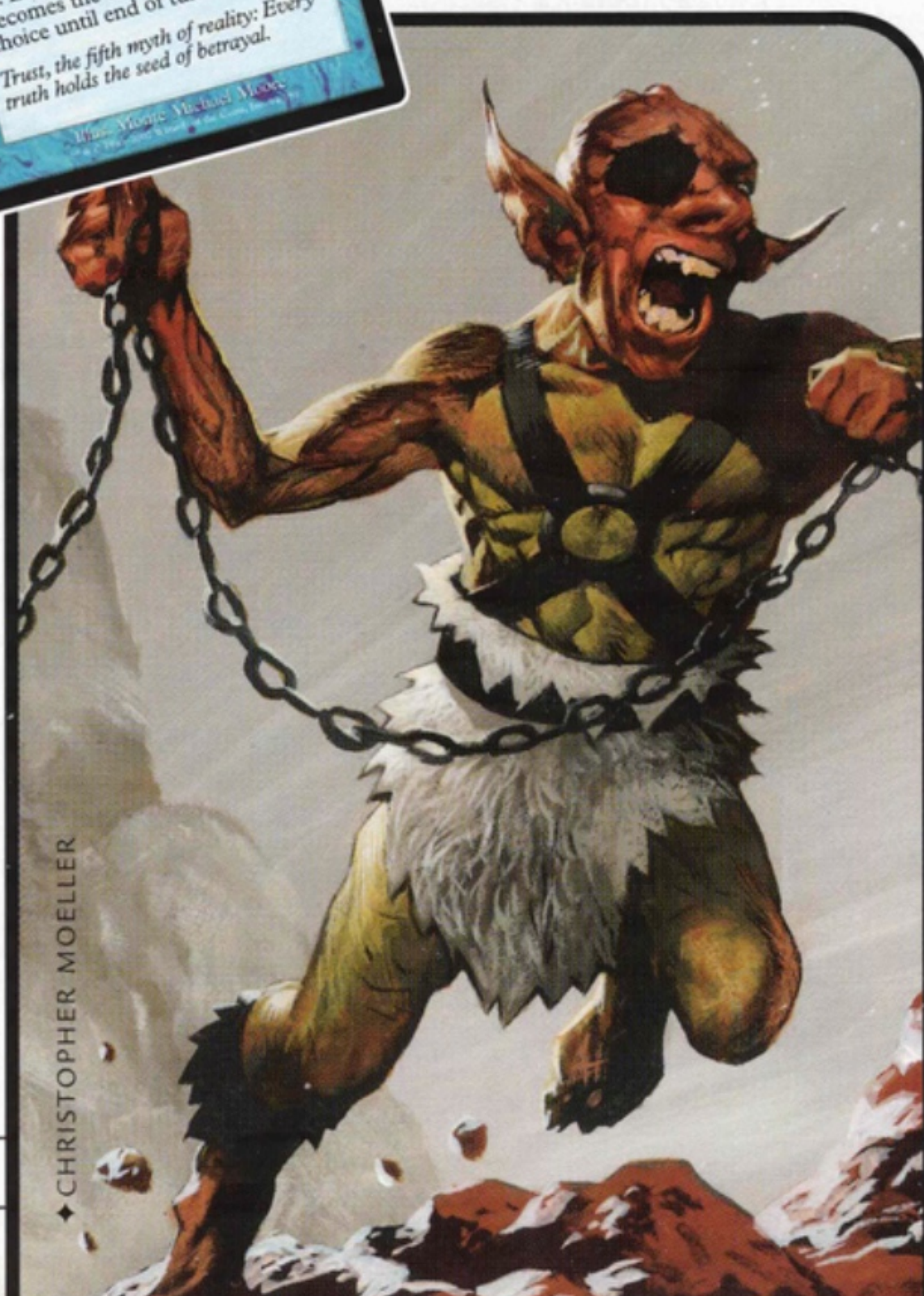


EIGHTEEN AND LOVING IT

There has never been a Sealed environment in which playing with eighteen lands has been as integral to limited success as it is with *Onslaught/Legions*. Kai Budde went as far as to say that, even in a straight two color deck, he "doesn't even think about playing less than eighteen." Why this dramatic change from *Odyssey* block, where the status quo was seventeen lands? First, *Onslaught/Legions* Sealed is tempo-based. Creatures start coming out on turn two, and they don't stop coming until both players' hands are emptied. Missing an early land drop is devastating; playing eighteen lands reduces that risk. Second is the cycling land factor. With seventeen basics and a cyclor, one has the best of both worlds—reduced odds of missing land drops and the ability to cycle a dead draw in the late game.

CREATURE ENCHANTMENTS: OKAY

The creature-heavy, removal-light environment of *Onslaught/Legions* turns cards that would be chaff in other blocks into powerhouses. Creature enchantments, usually thought to have gone extinct with the advent of the card advantage theorem, have found their niche in this Sealed format. Perhaps this is best shown by revealing the best-kept secret of *Onslaught/Legions* Sealed Deck: Crown of Fury. There are two reasons why the red Crown has found a place in my heart as the "new Ghostly Wings." First, first strike is a valuable ability when both players have almost nothing but creatures. Throw in the +1/+0 bonus and the ability to occasionally put your opponent in an uncomfortable blocking situation, and one gets a great little card that's a perfect addition to any aggressive deck. Second is its synergy with provoke. If Goblin Grappler with Crown of Fury is the poor man's Sparksmith, then I want to be a very poor man. Well, not poor in real life—I don't want to be a hobo. I just like Goblin Grapplers.



THE SKIRK EPIDEMIC IS OVER

At this year's Grand Prix—Los Angeles, I saw a very interesting phenomenon: certain pros were taking Battering Craghorn over Skirk Commando (the better card.) Peter Szigeti summed up why: "People always block." It was dubbed "The Skirk Epidemic." Players who hadn't memorized the common run of morph creatures or were just plain paranoid were blocking the third-turn morph creature much more often than they should. With the addition of *Legions*, this theory loses a lot of credence. Players know the common morphs from *Onslaught* well now, and that the number that are dangerous when unblocked (Skirk Commando, Haunted Cadaver, and Riptide Entrancer) pales in comparison to the number that punish players for blocking (Battering Craghorn, Snarling Underak, Daru Lancer, and so on). Also, very few *Legions* morph creatures are threatening when unblocked. What that means is that the turn three morph creature is much less likely to be blocked now than in pure *Onslaught* Sealed. This is handy when building your deck; the stock of cards like Skirk Commando, Haunted Cadaver, and Cabal Executioner rises sharply.

TURNING TRICKS FOR FUN & PROFIT

I'll keep it short and sweet—one-mana tricks and spells are the bread and butter of this format. This is due mostly to tempo and mana curve issues. Also, one-mana cyclers are great additions for their ability to smooth out mana ratios while occasionally serving useful purposes. Here's a quick list of the cheap and versatile commons and uncommons that often prove pivotal in the early turns of Sealed games: Vitality Charm, Wirewood Pride, Goblin Grappler, Goblin Sledder, Shock, Deftblade Elite, Piety Charm, Wall of Hope, Fade from Memory, Festering Goblin, Backslide, Mage's Guile, Chain of Vapor, and Imagecrafter. Oh yeah, and Spy Network. Kidding, kidding.



A WALL BY ANY OTHER NAME . . .

In discussions concerning pure *Onslaught* Limited, a lot has been said about Mistform Wall. Many have gone so far as to name it the top blue common in *Onslaught*. When was the last time you remember a common Wall being a first-pick caliber card? Having nothing but creatures can do strange things to a Limited environment, and this is a prime example. Walls are fantastic in *Onslaught/Legions* Limited. I've emphasized the importance of maintaining tempo in this format, and that is why Walls (and other early defensive creatures) are such assets. The opponent, going first, plays Glory Seeker and a face-down creature. Normally, drawing, this is a tough situation. Now imagine you have a Wall of Hope in play. Throw down a flyer and the race becomes academic. Anything that costs three or less and can survive blocking a morph creature is valid. Here are some defensive creatures that belong in almost any sealed deck (even an aggressive one): Crypt Sliver, Wall of Hope, Wall of Mulch, Mistform Wall, Riptide Biologist, Battlefield Medic, Wall of Deceit, Beacon of Destiny, and Starlight Invoker.



THE WRETCHED ANURID DILEMMA

Don't play Wretched Anurid in this format. I don't care how aggressive your deck is—it's not worth it. Consider Wellwisher, Disciple of Grace, Riptide Biologist, Wall of Mulch, Symbiotic Elf, Pacifism, and Sandskin. Consider the fact that most sealed decks have upwards of twenty creatures, and both players will be playing one or two, per turn, for the rest of the game. With the addition of *Legions*, Wretched Anurid has become, like smoking, a filthy habit to be done away with. Yes, it's kind of cool at first, but in the end it'll probably kill you.



PLAYING FIRST, PARTY OF 1

In the past, most pros felt strongly about drawing in Sealed. This was because, more often than not, both players had shaky tri-color mana bases, and the Sealed format was so much slower than Draft that the extra card was much more valuable than the tempo boost gained from playing first. Not so in *Onslaught/Legions* Sealed. First, getting to play the first morph guy is a considerable advantage. If you play a Skirk Commando, the onus is on them to block. If you play a Skirk Marauder, you can destroy their morph creature. Essentially, whoever plays first controls the pace of the game. Second, even if decks are tri-colored with shaky mana bases, most have eighteen land and colorless spells (morphs), two insurances against mana screw. You came to play. Act like it.



BRAWLERS BEHAVING BADLY

Here's a rule of thumb for using Embalmed Brawler: Ninety percent of the time, the right number to name for the amplify ability is one, no matter how many Zombies you have in hand. A 3/3 for three mana is a great deal that's tough to block, and the 1 life lost from attacking or blocking with it is much more manageable than any other number. When the Brawler has two or more counters on it, it often gets chump blocked until its owner is in a difficult situation. Embalmed Brawler is a very underrated card in *Onslaught/Legions* Limited; I recommend playing it whenever feasible.

TWO BEARS FOR EVERY BOY

Part of the reason that *Legions* has raised the bar on the importance of tempo is the addition of several "bears," two-mana creatures with 2 power. Previously, there had only been a handful, but now, almost every color but blue has one or two common bears. What this means is that the environment has become faster. Keep this in mind when cutting the last few cards from your sealed deck (perhaps that last fatty should be cut instead of the early drop) and when playing (to keep up, a turn two face-up Skintinner isn't always a bad play). Make sure your deck can deal with a steady stream of creatures starting on turn two.

That concludes my *Onslaught/Legions* Sealed Deck primer. I know we're older, but hopefully we're a little wiser too. Good luck in all your Sealed Deck endeavors!

